

FILLING IN THE GAPS

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Demonstrate increased organization of and attention to daily routines resulting in personal responsibilities being fulfilled.
2. Increase proficiency in daily living skills and knowledge of available community resources.
3. Prioritize independent activities of daily living (IADLs) upon which to focus efforts and improve functioning.
4. Take responsibility for own IADLs up to the level of the client's potential and develop resources for obtaining help from others.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE SELF-CARE DEFICITS—SECONDARY

- Assessing My Needs
- Assessing Self-Care Deficits
- Building My Support Network
- Coping with Addiction and Thought Disorders
- How Independent Am I?
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Relating Self-Care Deficits to My Addiction
- Using My Support Network
- Working toward Independence

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Living Environment Deficiencies
- Psychosis
- Self-Care Deficits—Primary

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Filling in the Gaps” exercise is designed for use with the client who has deficits in secondary self-care skills. As with the previous exercise in this section, “Assessing Self-Care Deficits,” this activity may be done with the client, family, caseworkers, or guardians, depending on the client's current level of functioning. It is useful to emphasize the connection between mastering these skills

and creating a stable and solid recovery program. It may be necessary to consider literacy, educational level, cultural differences, family values, gender differences, environmental barriers, and other mental health issues when assessing deficits and working toward solutions. Role-playing can be used to allow clients to practice actual skills individually or in a group format. This helps to decrease anxiety, increase confidence, and prepare for pitfalls. Follow-up could include a discussion of perceived versus actual barriers and ways to work through each.

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Sometimes, as part of managing our daily lives, we have to do things we aren't good at or interested in. Neglecting day-to-day responsibilities, however, creates stress and can put our independence and stability in jeopardy. We cannot always rely on others to do these things for us, even if they have done so in the past. As a result of addiction, we may have managed our responsibilities poorly and/or created additional problems that have become important to resolve. We have to include these daily responsibilities in our recovery plans. This exercise will help you to determine what areas you need to address and see how you can begin to do so.

1. Following is a sample list of independent activities of daily living and examples of each.
 - a. **Financial responsibilities** (e.g., opening accounts, balancing the checkbook, preparing and following a budget, paying bills, paying taxes).
 - b. **Medical responsibilities for self and/or children** (e.g., scheduling and attending appointments, filling prescriptions).
 - c. **Educational/occupational responsibilities** (e.g., being on time, applying for jobs, interacting with coworkers, performing assigned tasks, using study skills, managing time).
 - d. **Legal responsibilities** (e.g., keeping court dates, finding counsel, attending required appointments, telling work supervisors about these responsibilities and limitations).
 - e. **Accessing community resources** (e.g., dealing with transportation, daycare, support group meetings, financial assistance, church/spiritual activities, planning for emergencies).

2. Review the previous list. In which areas do you believe there are deficits in your life?

3. For all of the deficits you listed in response to question 2, please decide what barriers keep you from successfully completing those responsibilities (e.g., lack of organization, lack of attention, lack of motivation, need for more information or skills training).

4. List in order of importance, from most to least important, which of the problem areas from question 2 you need to address soonest.

5. With the help of your caseworker or therapist, use this space to create a step-by-step plan for working through the first item from question 4. Please be sure to include what you will do, in what order, when, and how. Be as specific as possible.

6. Start carrying out your plan and check in with your therapist, caseworker, or group members frequently at first about your progress and challenges. Remember that some of these skills take time and practice to master, but they do get easier over time, and each skill you learn will make it easier to learn additional skills.

Be sure to bring this handout with you to your future therapy sessions, and be prepared to discuss your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.